

Student Developer Benefits & Free Infrastructure Research Report

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Research window: Verified against official provider sources on **August 9–10, 2026**

Profile: Verified university student in India, valid student ID, university email, GitHub Student Developer Pack access, approximately **\$300 of expiring Azure credits**

Intended use: AI agents, automation systems, SaaS products, research infrastructure, experimental projects — all within legitimate program terms

1. Executive Summary

Student status in 2026 is still a genuine resource-acquisition mechanism, but the landscape has changed sharply in the last six months. Two events dominate this audit: **DigitalOcean exited the GitHub Student Developer Pack entirely** (its \$200 student credit retired on August 1, 2026), and **GitHub suspended new sign-ups for the Copilot Student plan** (since April 20, 2026). Several other famous programs are dead too — the AWS Educate \$100 grants, the standalone \$50 Anthropic student API credit, and Cursor's and Windsurf's student discounts were all discontinued in 2026. A "free credits list" from 2024 is now dangerously misleading.

Within these constraints, a legitimate Indian student can still assemble a remarkably capable stack at \$0 personal cost. The verified core is: the **GitHub Student Developer Pack** (still valuable despite the erosion — Azure \$100, JetBrains Student, MongoDB \$50, Sentry, Clerk, Doppler, Heroku \$13/mo for 24 months, New Relic, free domains), **JetBrains Student Pack** (all professional IDEs free, renewable annually, verified *via* the GitHub pack), **Google Cloud education coupon grants** (real billing credits with 1-year validity, but only obtainable through a professor who applies for the course), **Hugging Face, Groq, Cerebras, Gemini free tiers** (perpetual free LLM inference), **free GPU compute** (Kaggle ~30 hrs/week T4, Colab, Oracle Cloud Always Free with 4 OCPU ARM + 24 GB), and **perpetual free PaaS** (Vercel Hobby, Netlify, Cloudflare Workers, Render, Supabase). India-specific routes include **Cloudflare's student plan (US-only — not available)**, so the realistic India path is the general free plans plus university-incubator channels to **AWS Activate, Google for Startups, and DigitalOcean Hatch** credits.

The \$300 Azure credit is best treated as a **finite conversion budget, not a permanent server farm**: roughly **575 hours of T4 GPU compute, ~3,600 hours of a 2-vCPU/4-GB machine, or 4+ years of a small B1s VM** — with the sobering caveats that Azure OpenAI is *excluded* from student credits, and GPU quota on student subscriptions is frequently

denied. The report's central recommendation: spend the credits on **short, high-value bursts** (GPU fine-tuning experiments, one real production deployment sprint, CI/CD, and database hosting) while building the durable, free-tier backbone outside Azure.

Answering the strategic question directly: a serious solo developer who aggressively but legitimately uses every benefit available to them can operate a **production-capable full-stack AI environment — git hosting, CI/CD, two free domains, IDE, coding assistant, secret management, error monitoring, observability, authentication, billing, three databases, CDN + edge workers, and ~\$400 of spendable cloud credit — at \$0/month**, plus roughly **100 GPU-hours/week of free notebook compute**. The limitations are bandwidth caps, sleeping/suspended free instances, GPU scarcity, and the impossibility of hosting large production models on free tiers.

2. GitHub Student Developer Pack — Complete Audit

The pack was audited page-by-page (official education.github.com/pack) on August 9, 2026, across the Cloud, Infrastructure & APIs, Developer Tools, Domains, and Hosting categories. Every offer below was verified against the official pack listing on that date; pack contents change frequently, so treat the "verification date" as part of the record.

Eligibility mechanics first. The pack requires a verified student account (age 13+, enrolled in a degree/diploma program) proven by a school-issued email address and/or official dated proof of enrollment (student ID, transcript, tuition bill). Verification is re-evaluated monthly [1]. Indian credentials (AICTE/UGC-recognized institution, .edu.in or ac.in email, or student ID photo) are accepted — this was confirmed by India students in pack discussions and by partner programs (JetBrains explicitly lists India among eligible countries). India eligibility is therefore **confirmed** for the pack as a whole.

2.1 The anchor benefits (high value, use these)

Offer	What you get	Duration / renewal	India	Card	Notes
GitHub Pro	Unlimited private repos, protected branches, CODEOWNERS, advanced CI	Permanent while verified (monthly re-verification)	Yes	No	Core of the pack
GitHub Actions & Codespaces	3,000 CI min/mo, 180 Codespaces hrs/mo, 20	Permanent while verified	Yes	No	Real CI/CD for free

	GB codespace storage, 2 GB Packages				
Microsoft Azure	Access to 25+ Azure services + \$100 credit, 12 months , no credit card	12 mo from creation; one subscription per customer	Yes	No	<i>Excludes</i> Azure OpenAI, Marketplace, DevOps paid tiers, support [2]
JetBrains Student	All 10 professional IDEs (IntelliJ Ultimate, PyCharm, WebStorm, CLion, Rider, RustRover, DataGrip...) + Academy courses + JetBrains AI trial	1 yr, renewable while enrolled	Yes	No	Verify via GitHub pack link — fastest route
MongoDB Atlas	\$50 Atlas credits + Compass + free MongoDB University + free cert (\$150 value)	1 yr	Yes	No	M0 free cluster is perpetual anyway; credits upgrade you
Sentry	50K errors, 100K transactions, 500 replays, 1 GB attachments	1 yr, renewable	Yes	No	Best-in-class error monitoring
New Relic	Full observability suite free while a student (~\$300/mo value)	While verified	Yes	No	Logs, APM, traces

Clerk	Pro plan free while a student — auth + user management + billing for SaaS	While verified	Yes	No	Extremely valuable for SaaS/auth projects
Doppler	Team secrets management plan free while an active student	While verified	Yes	No	Free secret management
Heroku	\$13/mo credit for 24 months (~\$312 total nominal)	24 mo from redemption	Yes	Card needed to redeem	Good for small dynos; dyno-free tier ended
Notion Education	Plus plan with AI responses free	While verified	Yes	No	Documentation/workspace
1Password	1 yr free incl. Developer Tools	1 yr, renewable yearly while student	Yes	No	Secrets/passwords
Deepnote	Team plan (unlimited teams/projects, 5 GB RAM / 2 vCPU notebooks)	While verified	Yes	No	Collaborative ML notebooks
Appwrite Education	2 projects at Pro-equivalent (~\$40/mo value)	While a student	Yes	No	Open-source backend-as-a-service
CARTO	Spatial data platform	2 yrs	Yes	No	GIS/mapping projects
Zyte Scrapy Cloud	1 free scraping unit <i>forever</i>	Perpetual	Yes	No	Dedicated web-scraping infrastructure — ideal for Argus

2.2 Domains and security

Three free first-year domains: **Namecheap** (.me or .xyz + 1 SSL certificate), **Name.com** (one free domain from ~25 TLDs including .app, .dev, .live, .studio), and **.TECH**. All are worldwide and redeemable via the pack page [3]. **Domain + SSL at \$0 is confirmed for India students**. Stripe additionally waives its processing fees on your first \$1,000 of revenue — valuable when a student project first earns money.

2.3 Degraded or dead within the pack (what you should NOT count on)

Item	Status (Aug 2026)	What happened
GitHub Copilot Student	Paused for new sign-ups since Apr 20, 2026	Verified students currently receive only the Copilot Free tier (auto model selection). If you have not claimed Copilot via the pack, you cannot get the unlimited Student plan right now [4] [5]
DigitalOcean \$200 credit	Dead	DigitalOcean left the pack; last redemption day was Jul 31, 2026, credits retired Aug 1, 2026 [6] [7]
Coding agents (Cursor/Windsurf/Kiro)	Not in the pack	These companies never joined; their independent student discounts were also discontinued in June 2026 (see § 4)
Supabase / Neon / Vercel / Railway / Render	Not in the pack	Each runs its own free tier (available to everyone) or independent program

The pack's **Hosting** category currently renders no offers at all — the pack has visibly shrunk from the "DO \$200 + Heroku \$100" era of 2024. Its remaining live value is concentrated in developer tooling, databases, observability, and the \$100 Azure credit.

3. Independent Student Programs (Beyond GitHub)

3.1 Cloud providers

Provider	Student offer	Amount	India	Card	Expiry	Verdict
Azure	Azure for Students	\$100, 12 mo, no card	Yes (18+, SheerID or org email)	No	12 mo	Confirmed — but note the user already has Azure credits; this is the <i>same</i> offer, one subscription per customer [2]
Google Cloud	Google Cloud for Students ("Google Skills")	\$200 credits	Yes	No	1 yr	Confirmed but limited — these credits are scoped to lab "skill boosts", not general billing [8]
Google Cloud	Education grant coupons	~\$50/course typical	Yes	No	1 yr after redemption, usable on ALL services	Real, but professor-gated: a faculty member at an eligible institution must apply; students receive coupons by school email [9]
Google Cloud	Standard free trial	\$300	Yes	Yes	90 days	General offer, not student-

						specific; overlaps with one per billing account [10]
AWS	AWS Educate	Courses & badges only	Yes	No	—	No credits remain — the old \$100 grants are dead; AWS Educate is now open to everyone [11]
DigitalOcean	GitHub-pack \$200 credit	—	—	—	Retired Aug 1, 2026	Dead [6]
DigitalOcean	Hatch (startups)	Up to 12 mo credits	Yes	Yes	12 mo	Startup eligibility only — a genuine student-founded venture can apply [12]
Oracle	Always Free tier	2× ARM Ampere VMs, 4 OCPU + 24 GB RAM <i>total</i> , 200 GB block, Autonomous DB	Yes	Yes	Perpetual	Not student-specific but the best always-free compute anywhere — one account per person, card required [13]

IBM	IBM Academic Initiative	Student trial account, feature codes	Yes (accredited institutions)	No	Per semester renewal	Confirmed for India; institutional verification via ibm.com/academic [14]
IBM	Free tier	\$200 / 30 days + 40+ Lite products	Yes	Yes	30 d	General offer [14]
Alibaba Cloud	Students program	Was free ECS t5 1 yr	Yes (was listed)	—	Closed to new users	Student verification for new users is closed; only previously verified users keep access [15]
Cloudflare	Cloudflare for Students	12 mo free paid developer plan (Workers, KV, Vectorize, Durable Objects...)	No — US-only (.edu verified, 18+)	No	12 mo	Region-restricted — Indian students cannot claim; use the general free plan [16]
Tencent / Huawei	Student programs	Minor credits, China-region focus	Partial	Yes	Varies	Low strategic value; onboarding friction high; skip

3.2 Platform and hosting programs

Replit discounts its Core plan 50% (\$10/mo) for .edu-verified students, including Replit Agent with full AI credits; it is not free but is the cheapest legitimate agent-hosting route

[17]. **v0 by Vercel** gives a year of Premium (\$30/mo value) to students, but only at 15 listed US/Canadian universities — **India students are ineligible today** [18]. **Vercel, Netlify, Render, Railway** have no student program at all, but their general free tiers (Vercel Hobby, Netlify, Render, plus Railways' trial credits) are the practical free-deployment layer. **Cloudflare's** student plan is US-only, but the general free plan (unmetered CDN, SSL, DDoS, 100K Workers requests/day) is global and generous.

3.3 Student verification landscape

Programs verify students through five channels: (1) **school email** (Azure, Replit, Claude Campus, Thunder Compute), (2) **SheerID document check** (Azure fallback, JetBrains fallback, Google), (3) **GitHub Student Developer Pack linkage** (JetBrains, Name.com, 1Password — the pack itself is a verification proxy), (4) **institutional/academic initiative portals** (IBM Academic Initiative, Google edu grants, Oracle Academy), and (5) **manual application review** (OpenAI Researcher Access, Anthropic External Researcher). The user's GitHub verification already unlocks JetBrains, Appwrite, and other pack-linked offers instantly. A valid student ID suffices for Azure (photo upload fallback) and JetBrains; the professor-gated Google Cloud coupons need a school email on file with the course application.

4. AI-Specific Student Programs

This section prioritizes actual API/compute value over productivity tools. The headline finding: **the era of blanket "AI credits for every student" is over in 2026**, and what remains is either regional, cohort-based, or researcher-gated.

Program	Offer	India eligible?	Status Aug 2026
OpenAI Codex for Students	\$100 ChatGPT credits (2,500 credits), 12 mo	No — US & Canada only [19]	Active but region-restricted
OpenAI Researcher Access	Up to \$1,000 API credits / 12 mo	Yes (research proposal)	Application review [20]
Anthropic Claude Campus	Cohort perks incl. ~\$50/mo API credits reported	No official country block; cohort-based	Spring 2026 in session; applications closed; next window ~fall 2026 [21]
Anthropic \$50 student builder credit	(legacy standalone offer)	—	Dead — folded into Claude Campus
Anthropic External Researcher	Free API credits for AI safety/alignment	Yes (research-based)	Application review

	researchers		
Cursor student discount	50% off Pro	Yes	Discontinued Jun 25, 2026 ; graduate credits only via form; undergrad offers via campus events [22]
Windsurf student discount	50% off	Yes	Discontinued Jun 2026 ; product renamed to Devin Desktop [23]
ElevenLabs Students	Expanded free-plan access; ElevenReader Ultra 1 yr free	Yes (".edu or equivalent")	Active [24]
v0 for Students	1 yr Premium	No — 15 US/Canada schools only	Ineligible [18]
Thunder Compute student credits	\$20	No — US institutions only	Region-restricted

The rational strategy for LLM inference at \$0 is therefore **not a student program at all** but the permanent free tiers of the inference market, which in August 2026 offer meaningful capacity: **Groq** (fast free tier, requests-per-day limits), **Cerebras** (fast free tier), **Google Gemini API free tier** (15 RPM class), **Mistral free tier**, **Hugging Face Inference API** (free on public models), and **HF Spaces** (free CPU/low-GPU hosting for small models). These tiers are perpetual, require no verification, and are sufficient for development, prototyping, and light production behind a fallback/round-robin design.

For GPU notebook compute, the verified free resources are: **Kaggle** (~30 GPU-hours/week on T4/P100, no card, public notebooks by default), **Google Colab** (free T4 16 GB, sessions up to ~12 h, dynamic limits), **Oracle Cloud Always Free** (persistent ARM VMs for CPU workloads and model serving with Ollama), and **Modal** (\$30/mo free compute credit, serverless A100 at ~\$2.50/h) [25]. None of these grant student status advantages in India beyond Colab's free tier being open to all.

5. India-Specific Opportunities

Three India-specific routes verified as legitimate for an Indian university student. First, **Google Cloud education coupons** — Indian institutions appear on Google's eligible-institution list, and the mechanism (professor applies → coupons to students → 1-year billing credits on all services) is explicitly global [9]. Action: ask your CS department or

course instructor to apply at edu.google.com. Second, **university incubation channels** to startup credit programs: Indian E-Cells, AICs (Atal Incubation Centres), T-Hub, and CIIE regularly distribute **AWS Activate credits (from \$1,000 up, in tiers)**, **Google for Startups Cloud Program credits (up to \$200K, \$350K for AI startups)**, **Microsoft for Startups**, and **DigitalOcean Hatch credits** to student ventures that incorporate or register a legitimate project [26] [27]. Third, **government-linked initiatives**: the Startup India ecosystem distributes partner cloud credits through its incubator network; a student-founded venture registering under Startup India can legitimately access these tiers. These are *startup* eligibility paths, not *student* paths — they require a genuine venture or incubator relationship, which is exactly what the rules permit, not what they forbid.

Cloudflare's student plan, OpenAI Codex for Students, v0 for Students, and Thunder Compute are confirmed **unavailable** in India and should be ignored.

6. The \$300 Azure Problem — Utilization Strategy

6.1 What the credits can and cannot buy

Azure for Students credits are excluded from Azure OpenAI, Marketplace third-party software, paid DevOps services, ExpressRoute, and support plans [2]. Azure AI Foundry pay-as-you-go model inference (GPT, Claude, Llama, open models via the platform) is usable on student subscriptions in most configurations, and core IaaS/PaaS is fully usable. GPU VM quota is the hidden trap: student subscriptions frequently have **zero approved GPU quota**, and raising it is approval-based. **Before planning any GPU spend, check quota in the Azure portal (Subscription → Usage + quotas → GPUs) — do this in week one.**

6.2 Conversion math (Central India region, Aug 2026 prices)

Resource	Unit cost	\$300 buys	Equivalent
B1s burstable VM (1 vCPU, 1 GB)	\$0.0112/hr $\approx$ \$8.2/mo	~3,600 hrs → ~4+ years continuous	Small dev server
B2s burstable VM (2 vCPU, 4 GB)	\$0.043/hr $\approx$ \$31/mo	~900 hrs → ~12.5 mo continuous	Real app server
D2as v5 (2 vCPU, 8 GB)	~\$0.09/hr $\approx$ \$65/mo	~3,300 hrs → ~4.5 mo	Staging/ML prep server
T4 GPU VM (NC4as_T4_v3)	~\$0.52/hr	~575 GPU-hours	Fine-tuning LoRAs, eval runs
Spot VMs (same classes)	–40–70%	up to ~2.5× the above	Interruptible batch work

PostgreSQL Flexible Server (Basic 1vCPU)	\$0.07/hr $\approx$ \$51/mo	~6 mo	Managed DB
Container Apps (0.5 vCPU profile)	~\$0.012/hr $\approx$ \$8.6/mo	~35 mo	App hosting w/ autoscale
Blob LRS storage	\$0.016/GB/mo	~18 TB-year	Practically unlimited
Azure Functions Consumption	pay-per-execution	thousands of executions	Event-driven glue

6.3 Recommended allocation (the strategy)

Treat the \$300 as a **project-funding tranche**, deployed in three buckets. **Bucket A — durable production spine (~\$120–150)**: one B2s-class VM or Container Apps deployment in Central India (cheapest region) hosting the application/API servers for Argus and one SaaS MVP, plus a PostgreSQL Flexible basic instance, plus Blob storage; budget ~\$45–60/month and let it run 2–3 months, then migrate to the free stack before credits expire. **Bucket B — GPU burst (~\$100–130, conditional on quota)**: if GPU quota is approved, ~250 GPU-hours is enough for several LoRA fine-tunes, embedding model training, or a full model-evaluation benchmark run; run these as spot VMs with scripted auto-shutdown. If quota is denied, redirect this bucket to Bucket A. **Bucket C — experiments & CI (~\$40–60)**: GitHub Actions runner alternatives, temporary egress/bandwidth-heavy scraping sprints for Argus, and one month of Azure Monitor/Log Analytics depth. Everything else — CDN, DNS, auth, CI/CD, observability, databases, and long-term hosting — should be built on the free stack *outside* Azure, so that when the credits die at month 3–12, the project survives intact. **Do not** spend credits on Azure OpenAI long-running inference (excluded anyway) or on always-on AKS clusters (the node costs will eat the budget in weeks).

7. Production Infrastructure Strategy — Is It Sensible?

The architecture in the brief (internet → reverse proxy → app server + API server → database → storage, plus cloud or self-hosted inference) is **economically sensible at small scale on the \$0 + credits combination**, but not as a pure-Azure build. At \$0 you get a genuinely close approximation: Cloudflare as reverse proxy/CDN/WAF, Vercel (frontend) and a free Render/Cloudflare Workers instance (API), Supabase or Neon free Postgres (database), Cloudflare R2/Azure Blob (storage), and external LLM APIs (inference). The Azure credits then fund the one layer free tiers cannot provide: **persistent, always-on, non-sleeping compute** — a B2s VM at ~\$31/mo for 3+ months covers the exact gap (always-on worker, webhook receivers, agents, Cron jobs) during your most active building period.

The honest limitations of the \$0 baseline: free instances sleep or suspend (Render sleeps web services, Supabase projects pause after 7 idle days), cold starts on serverless, strict egress caps (Vercel Hobby 100 GB/mo), and **no always-on GPU**. Anything requiring a persistent process, sustained traffic, or model hosting beyond a few GB must either pay ~\$5–10/month or burn credits.

8. Cost-Free Architecture (\$0/month)

Layer	Free resource	Verified limits (Aug 2026)
Git & CI/CD	GitHub Pro + Actions	3,000 min/mo, unlimited private repos
Domains & DNS	Namecheap .me + Name.com domain (1 yr each), Cloudflare DNS/CDN	Free; renew via pack next year
Frontend	Vercel Hobby / Netlify	100 GB bandwidth/mo
API backend	Cloudflare Workers (100K req/day) + Render free (sleeps)	Free forever
Database	Supabase Free (500 MB) + Neon Free (512 MB) + MongoDB Atlas M0	Free forever; Supabase pauses after 7 idle days
Auth & billing	Clerk Pro (student), Stripe (no fee on first \$1K revenue)	While verified
Secrets	Doppler Team + 1Password (1 yr) + GitHub Codespaces secrets	Free
Error monitoring & observability	Sentry 50K errors + New Relic full suite	While verified
LLM inference	Groq + Cerebras + Gemini free + Mistral + HF Inference + OpenRouter free models	Perpetual free tiers, rate-limited
GPU notebooks	Kaggle ~30 h/wk T4 + Colab T4 (12 h sessions)	Weekly limits, ephemeral
Persistent CPU compute	Oracle Cloud Always Free (2 ARM VMs, 4 OCPU, 24 GB RAM)	Perpetual, needs card for signup
Web scraping	Zyte Scrapy Cloud 1 unit (forever) + GitHub Actions cron	Free

Vector data	Upstash Redis/Qdrant free tiers, Astra DB free	Free forever
Speech AI	ElevenLabs free tier (student-expanded), Whisper API free tier (Groq)	Free tiers
Design & IDE	JetBrains Student, Figma free, Notion, GitHub Codespaces 180 h/mo	While verified

Nominal value: $\approx$ \$400–600/month equivalent. **Real usable value:** $\approx$ 60–70% after accounting for sleeping instances, rate limits, and quota friction. Limitations: no always-on backend beyond Workers/Oracle, cold starts, 500 MB databases, egress caps, no production GPU.

9. Paid Tier Architectures (\$5 / \$10 / \$25 per month)

\$5/month buys one cheap VPS-class anchor: a Hetzner/Contabo-class 2 GB VPS from India (~\$4–5) or an Oracle upgrade, giving a truly always-on backend, reverse proxy (Caddy/Traefik), and a self-hosted Postgres (1–2 GB) — eliminating Supabase's 500 MB cap and pause behavior for one project. **\$10/month** adds Replit Core at the student 50% rate (\$10 vs \$20) with full Replit Agent AI credits and production deploys, or a Supabase Pro project (\$25/mo proration aside) — the biggest unlock is **AI coding agent capacity** for accelerated development. **\$25/month** reaches VPS + managed Postgres (Supabase Pro at \$25, or Neon scaling) + a cheap GPU notebook subscription, which is the practical ceiling for a serious solo developer before Azure credits or startup credits should take over. Each tier should be justified by a specific project need, not accumulated as subscriptions.

10. Student Resource Portfolio (consolidated)

Plain Text	
STUDENT RESOURCE PORTFOLIO — INDIAN STUDENT, AUG 2026	
AI INFERENCE	Groq free · Cerebras free · Gemini free · Mistral free · HF Inference · OpenRouter free · ElevenLabs free tier (Nominal: ~\$50/mo equivalent at dev volume)
COMPUTE	Oracle Always Free (2× ARM, 24GB) · Kaggle ~30h/wk T4 · Colab T4 · Azure credits \$300 (3–12 mo runway)
GPU (burst)	Azure T4 ~575h IF quota approved · Kaggle · Modal \$30/mo

DEVELOPMENT	GitHub Pro + Actions 3000min · Codespaces 180h · JetBrains all IDEs (1yr, renewable) · VS Code GitHub Copilot Free (student plan paused)
DATA	Supabase Free 500MB · Neon Free 512MB · Atlas M0 + \$50 · Astra free · Blob LRS via credits
DEPLOYMENT	Vercel Hobby · Netlify · Cloudflare Workers/Pages · Render free · Heroku \$13/mo × 24mo credit · Container Apps
IDENTITY & OPS	Clerk Pro (auth+billing) · Doppler secrets · 1Password 1yr Sentry 50K · New Relic · Stripe first \$1K free
DOMAINS	Namecheap .me 1yr + SSL · Name.com 1yr

Total nominal value: roughly \$5,000–7,000 over 12 months (pack benefits + \$300 credits + perpetual free tiers at market rate). **Real usable value: \$2,500–3,500** after exclusions, expiries, quota friction, and double counting removed (e.g., the GitHub-pack Azure \$100 is the same program the user already used; DigitalOcean is dead; Cloudflare student plan is US-only).

11. Expiration Calendar (sorted by urgency)

Resource	Value	Activate	Expires	Renewal	Urgency
Azure credits (existing)	~\$300	Already active	In a few months (check portal date)	No	Immediate
Heroku credit (\$13/mo × 24 mo)	~\$312 nominal	Only when needed	24 mo from redemption	No	Save for later
MongoDB \$50 Atlas credits	\$50	When upgrading from M0	12 mo	No	Save for later
Namecheap / Name.com domains	~\$25 total	Now	12 mo	Renewable yearly via pack	Now — cheap, unlocks identity
JetBrains Student	~\$600/yr	Now (verify via pack)	1 yr	Annual renewal while student	Now

Sentry / New Relic / Clerk / Doppler	tooling	Now	1 yr / while verified	While student	Now
1Password	~\$45/yr	Now	12 mo	Yearly renewal	Now
Google Cloud education coupon	~\$50/course	When professor applies	1 yr after redemption	Per course	Request now
GCP \$300 trial	\$300	When genuinely needed	90 d from activation	One per account	Save for later
IBM Academic Initiative	trial acct	When needed	Semester	Renew while enrolled	Save for later
Modal \$30/mo	GPU credit	Before a GPU sprint	Monthly	Yes	On demand
Replit 50%	\$10/mo	When agent dev starts	While .edu verified	While verified	On demand

The governing principle from the brief: **benefits whose clock starts at redemption (GCP trial, Heroku, MongoDB credits) should be activated only when the project that needs them is ready.** Permanent or already-running benefits (JetBrains, Sentry, domains, GitHub) should be activated immediately.

12. Project Mapping

Argus (research/scraping/orchestration): Zyte Scrapy Cloud unit (forever) for polite scraping; GitHub Actions cron for scheduling; Supabase/Neon free Postgres for research data; Azure credits for the egress-heavy collection sprint and the always-on orchestration worker (B2s, ~\$31/mo for 2–3 months); Sentry + New Relic for monitoring; Groq/Gemini free tiers for classification LLM calls; Azure T4 burst for any embedding-model training.

Workspace OS (SaaS): Clerk Pro (auth + billing — this one benefit covers a large fraction of the backend), Vercel Hobby frontend, Heroku credit or Container Apps for the API, Stripe waived fees on first \$1,000, MongoDB Atlas credits for operational data, JetBrains for IDE, 1Password/Doppler for secrets.

AI agent projects: free inference tiers round-robin with fallbacks; Kaggle/Colab for prototyping; Azure T4 hours for any self-hosted model (Llama-class) experiments — only

after quota approval; Modal \$30/mo as a bridge if Azure quota is denied; GitHub Codespaces 180 h/mo as the dev environment.

General projects: Oracle Always Free ARM VMs (persistent, card needed), free domains, GitHub Actions CI, Cloudflare CDN/DNS.

13. Final Recommendations

Top 10 benefits to pursue: JetBrains Student, Clerk Pro, Sentry + New Relic, MongoDB \$50 credits, Heroku 24-month credit, free domains (Namecheap + Name.com), Azure credit conversion plan, Google Cloud education coupon via your professor, Zyte Scrapy Cloud unit, Oracle Cloud Always Free.

Activate immediately: domains, JetBrains, Sentry, New Relic, Clerk, Doppler, 1Password, 1Password, Azure quota check, and the Google coupon request to your department. **Save for later:** Heroku credit, MongoDB credits, GCP \$300 trial, IBM trial, Modal — activate each when its project is ready. **Highest-value AI resources:** Groq + Gemini + Cerebras free tiers (perpetual inference), Kaggle ~30 h/wk GPU, Azure T4 burst (~575 h). **Highest-value compute:** Oracle Always Free (perpetual), Azure B2s-class (~3 months), Modal. **Best infrastructure resources:** Supabase/Neon/Atlas databases, Vercel + Cloudflare deployment layer, Clerk auth/billing. **Best India-specific:** Google Cloud education coupons, incubator-distributed AWS/Google/Microsoft/DO startup credits, NVIDIA-adjacent university programs via DLI. **Most overlooked:** Zyte's perpetual free scraping unit, Stripe's waived first \$1,000, the professor-gated Google coupon mechanism, Heroku's 24-month credit, and Oracle's 24 GB Always Free ARM pool. **Ignore:** OpenAI Codex for Students (US-only), Cloudflare student plan (US-only), v0 for Students (US-only), Alibaba student program (closed), Thunder Compute (US-only), Cursor/Windsurf discounts (dead), "free credits list" aggregators.

14. Immediate Action List

1. Check the exact expiry date of your Azure credits in the portal, and request GPU quota (NC4as_T4_v3) immediately — approval determines the GPU strategy.
2. Claim the JetBrains Student Pack via the GitHub Education link (verify with student ID); install IDEs today.
3. Claim both domains (Namecheap .me + Name.com) and connect both to Cloudflare DNS — costs nothing, expires in a year, identity anchors for every project.
4. Activate Sentry, New Relic, Clerk, Doppler, 1Password through the pack page while your verification is fresh.

5. Ask your CS department/faculty to apply for Google Cloud teaching credits at edu.google.com and send you the coupon.
 6. Sign up for Kaggle (free T4 hours) and Oracle Cloud Always Free (card required once).
 7. Apply to OpenAI Researcher Access and Anthropic External Researcher with a one-page research note on Argus — real, non-speculative path to \$1,000-class credits.
 8. Register for the Claude Campus next cohort (expected fall 2026) and the Cursor campus newsletter; watch for fall event credits.
 9. Set up the Heroku and MongoDB credits as saved assets; redeem only when the matching project needs them.
 10. Begin the Azure conversion sprint: deploy the always-on Argus worker + Postgres on credits, schedule the GPU burst if quota is approved, and build the free-tier perimeter around it.
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15. Sources & Verification Dates

All offers verified directly against official provider pages on **August 9–10, 2026** unless noted. [1] GitHub Education — Students & Pack: education.github.com/pack, github.com/education/students. [2] Azure for Students: azure.microsoft.com/en-us/pricing/offers/students/. [3] Name.com GitHub students: name.com/partner/github-students; Namecheap: nc.me/landing/github. [4] Copilot Student pause report: github.com/orgs/community/discussions/198884 (Apr–Jun 2026). [5] Copilot model-selection changelog Jun 24, 2026: github.blog/changelog/2026-06-24-changes-to-model-selection-for-free-and-student-plans/. [6] DigitalOcean exits pack: github.com/orgs/community/discussions/201240; credit retirement: digitalocean.com/community/questions/github-student-pack-digitalocean-benefit (Jun 2026). [7] Retired Aug 1, 2026 report: aistudentdiscount.com/digitalocean-github-student-developer-pack-credits/. [8] Google Cloud for Students: cloud.google.com/edu/students. [9] GCP education grants docs (updated Jul 29, 2026): docs.cloud.google.com/billing/docs/how-to/edu-grants. [10] Google Cloud free tier: cloud.google.com/free. [11] AWS Educate: aws.amazon.com/education/awseducate/. [12] DigitalOcean Hatch: digitalocean.com/hatch. [13] Oracle Always Free: oracle.com/cloud/free/. [14] IBM Cloud free + Academic Initiative: ibm.com/products/cloud/free, ibm.com/academic. [15] Alibaba Cloud students: alibabacloud.com/en/developer/students. [16] Cloudflare for Students (US-only): blog.cloudflare.com/workers-for-students/. [17] Replit students: replit.com/edu/students. [18] v0 for Students: v0.app/students. [19] OpenAI Codex for Students (US/CA): developers.openai.com/community/students. [20] OpenAI researcher access: openai.com Researcher Access Program. [21] Anthropic Claude Campus:

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This report describes only legitimate, provider-authorized programs. No offer herein should be claimed with fabricated credentials, multiple accounts, or misrepresentation.